Eshan Iyer

Ralph Bauer

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Connection Between Science and Utopia in *Utopia* & *The New Atlantis*

In *Utopia* and *The New Atlantis*, Thomas More and Francis Bacon depict ideal societies where science and learning are integral to social advancement. Although both works envision utopian societies driven by knowledge, their approaches to science reveal significant philosophical differences. More's *Utopia* uses science to reinforce social welfare and stability, while Bacon's *The New Atlantis* envisions science as the ultimate path to enlightenment and moral improvement. This essay argues that while More's *Utopia* reflects skepticism toward unchecked scientific authority, prioritizing social stability over intellectual ambition, Bacon's *The New Atlantis* celebrates science as a transformative moral force, promising societal enlightenment. By contrasting these visions, the essay reveals how both authors explore Renaissance anxieties about the limits of knowledge and authority, a tension that foreshadows modern ethical debates on the role of science in shaping societal ideals.

Thomas More's *Utopia* introduces readers to a structured, egalitarian society that employs science primarily for the maintenance of social order. Here, science serves the practical needs of the people, focusing on agriculture, medicine, and urban planning. More details on how Utopians manage their surplus resources: "When they have thus taken care of their whole country, and laid up stores for two years... they order a seventh part of all these goods to be freely given to the poor of the countries to which they send them" (More 93). This careful application of science

reflects More's critique of European economic inequality, where such communal support is lacking. By emphasizing collective welfare, *Utopia* models a society where science is controlled and applied carefully to prevent social disorder, echoing More's concern about Europe's failure to ensure basic resources for all.

While More's society values science, it imposes limitations on scientific inquiry, suggesting ambivalence about knowledge's influence on social dynamics. This restraint highlights More's caution regarding the potential dangers of intellectual pursuits that could disrupt social balance. For example, the Utopians avoid advanced weaponry, choosing peaceful methods for conflict resolution: "They do not devise arms and engines of war, but rather strive to find out the way to avoid wars altogether" (More 143). This strategy reveals their distrust of military advancement. Scholars such as Quentin Skinner argue that More's careful "control of science" reflects a "mirror of folly," a veiled critique of contemporary Europe's scientific advancements, which were often weaponized, undermining societal welfare (Skinner 84). More's restrained vision aligns with the Renaissance era's duality of progress and militarization, as scientific developments frequently served the interests of war. His *Utopia* thus questions whether knowledge alone can reform society, suggesting instead that wisdom and ethical restraint must temper scientific pursuits.

In contrast, Bacon's *The New Atlantis* presents science not as a limited tool for societal order but as an almost spiritual pursuit. Science pervades Bensalem's culture, spearheaded by Salomon's House, an institution dedicated to uncovering nature's secrets for the common good. Describing Salomon's House as "the noblest foundation … that ever was upon the earth, and the

lantern of this kingdom" (Bacon 20), Bacon elevates the pursuit of knowledge as a divine mission capable of improving humanity on moral, intellectual, and social levels.

Bacon's view reflects his vision of an ideal society where scientists act as moral agents, free from corruption or personal gain. Scholars like Lisa Jardine argue that Salomon's House embodies Bacon's vision of a scientific community that prioritizes the ethical implications of knowledge, advocating for a new approach to understanding the natural world through empirical methods and collaborative inquiry (Jardine 20). The members of Salomon's House are depicted as responsible stewards of their discoveries, exemplifying Bacon's faith in human reason and ethical accountability. This portrayal marks a significant distinction from More's vision; while More emphasizes societal control over science, Bacon glorifies scientific exploration as a force for moral and societal perfection.

The literary and rhetorical styles in *Utopia* and *The New Atlantis* reflect each author's stance on science and its implications for society. More employs a satirical style, adopting the fictional character Raphael Hythloday as a narrator whose account of Utopia can be read as both serious and ironic. This careful ambiguity suggests skepticism about the feasibility of a society fully dependent on science for social order. Raphael's observations are often paradoxical, prompting readers to question whether More endorses or critiques Utopia's values, including its reliance on science. According to Stephen Greenblatt, More's portrayal of Utopia serves as a cautionary tale, illustrating the potential dangers of an overly rational society that prioritizes scientific progress at the expense of human values and ethics (Greenblatt 112). This nuanced approach reflects More's skepticism regarding science as a standalone force for societal reform.

In contrast, Bacon's language is direct and almost reverent, expressing his genuine admiration for scientific inquiry. Bacon's depiction of Solomon's House blends ideals, with an approach by showcasing it as a place dedicated to the ethical and methodical pursuit of knowledge. His positive outlook resonates with the Enlightenment principles that were gaining prominence during his era – emphasizing reason as the key to progress. His unequivocal endorsement of science, as the bedrock of improvement starkly contrasts with More's doubtfulness.

The differences in these texts' perspectives on science reflect the historical contexts and personal philosophies of their authors. More, a Catholic humanist, lived during a period marked by religious and political upheaval, which influenced his skepticism about intellectual pursuits that could challenge established norms. His criticism aligns with Renaissance critiques of European society, where scientific advances were often exploited to support military power or economic dominance rather than public welfare. In contrast, Bacon was deeply invested in a "scientific renaissance" and held that knowledge could provide moral and intellectual benefits. His optimistic outlook reflects emerging Enlightenment ideas that advocated for reason as humanity's ultimate path to utopia. Unlike More, who critiques intellectual ambition as dangerous, Bacon exalts scientific inquiry, suggesting that if conducted responsibly, it could achieve a utopian society.

The contrasting strategies of representation in *Utopia* and *The New Atlantis* reveal differing ethical perspectives on scientific authority. More's narrative scrutinizes the ethical implications of scientific knowledge, cautioning against the potential for intellectual endeavors to destabilize social harmony. For example, the Utopians restrict scientific activity in medicine,

allowing treatments only in essential cases to avoid prioritizing physical well-being over societal needs (More 68). More's cautious approach to science critiques the Renaissance's intellectual ambition, foreshadowing modern concerns about unchecked scientific progress and ethical dilemmas in areas like genetic engineering and artificial intelligence.

Bacon, however, assumes that science aligns with ethical principles when conducted within moral institutions like Salomon's House. His faith in science's potential reflects a belief in rational inquiry, detached from political or economic motives, as a route to societal and personal enlightenment. This idealized institution promotes an unblemished pursuit of knowledge, suggesting that scientific understanding, when pursued responsibly, can yield fulfillment and societal harmony. Bacon's optimism exemplifies the Renaissance humanist conviction that comprehending nature can help humanity realize its highest potential.

Thomas More's *Utopia* and Francis Bacon's *The New Atlantis* explore the role of science in ideal societies, presenting unique perspectives on the relationship between knowledge, morality, and social harmony. *Utopia* advocates for science as a tool bound by social responsibility, cautious of the dangers of intellectual overreach. More's skepticism about unchecked knowledge highlights the necessity of ethical moderation. Conversely, Bacon's *The New Atlantis* celebrates scientific inquiry as the highest moral pursuit, portraying it as a path to societal enlightenment. These works capture Renaissance tensions surrounding science and knowledge, reflecting each author's response to intellectual progress's potential to create a utopian society. Through distinct literary techniques, historical context, and ethical scrutiny, More and Bacon offer readers contrasting views on science's role in utopia. The connection between science and society in *Utopia* and *The New Atlantis* underscores the complexities of

balancing progress with moral responsibility—a theme that continues to resonate in contemporary discussions on scientific ethics.

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